



ED LEVITT 50A

Earl Of Stixville

The town was jubilant. Honking cars motorcade down the main street. Men and women jammed the corners . . . hugging, kissing, shouting.

It was the night of Oct. 9, 1966, when the Baltimore Orioles became baseball's world champions.

They had recorded three straight shutouts and swept the Dodgers in four swift victories.

Frank Robinson was the triple crown batting champion and most valuable player.

Boog Powell was comeback player of the year. Brooks Robinson was all-universe at third base.

Frank, Boog and Brooks each drove in more than 100 runs.

"This is the best team put together since the 1927 Yankees," baseball people were saying.

A year later it was gone. And Hank Bauer, who was manager of the year in '66, was on his way out.

The Orioles brought in Earl Weaver to replace Bauer, and Weaver and the O's finished second in '68, first in '69 and on top again in '70.

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But who is Earl Weaver? What type of leader is this who takes his team to two straight World Series adventures and today will be guiding his Orioles against the Cincinnati Reds in the big Sunday morning spectacular on the telly?

Well, you know the old story about the baseball manager deep down in the bush leagues?

He has to be a fellow who can do everything. He is a manager, teacher, wet nurse, traveling secretary, ticket-taker and sometimes he drives the bus to the next town. And if the bus breaks down, he gets out and fixes it.

Earl Weaver spent more than half of his 40 years in Stixville, U.S.A., "but I never knew how to fix a bus," he says. "I just always hired a first baseman who also happened to be a mechanic."

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Weaver is baseball's oldest kind of warm story, the man who gets a chance in the big leagues after a lifetime of toiling in the minors.

He is the honest laborer, the fella who has gotten dirt on his uniform while learning his craft. He's an action guy and his Orioles play that way, too.

Earl Weaver is Earl Weaver, all right. But he is also Billy Jurges, Frankie Frisch, Joe McCarthy, Bill Rigney, Alvin Dark, Bobby Bragan, Charley Dressen, Gene Mauch, Solly Hemus and Eddie Stanky — meaning he's a little, middle-of-the-diamond infielder who has made it as a manager.

Weaver is like Casey Stengel in that he knows names and places. He played ball under Andy Cohen, the guy who replaced Rogers Hornsby as Giant second baseman in the 1920s.

He was hit in the back twice by Bob Turley in the first professional game Turley ever pitched. He can tell you what it's like in Dublin, Ga. ("It's hot with big horseflies and lots of gnats and they drive you crazy").

The highest Earl Weaver got in the majors as a player was to spring training camp with the Cardinals when Eddie Stanky was the manager.

He played second base every day for almost two weeks. When Red Schoendienst finished nursing an injury, Weaver found himself on the bench with the keen realization there would be no place for him in the big leagues.

"I thought I was good enough," he said, "but I could see they didn't think so."

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Earl Weaver was a big man in Baltimore when he won the pennant last year. But losing to the Mets in the World Series chopped him down to size — which in Earl's case is five-foot-seven.

And so, when the Orioles played their first game in Oakland after their horrendous Series flop, Weaver was the man everybody wanted to interview.

The night was warm and clear and there was a moon over the Coliseum.

In the Oriole dugout, Weaver was again asked about the eclipse of last October.

It was all he was asked about in the spring. He was asked specifically if his team is haunted by the memory.

"It's hard to forget," he said, "and I'm glad of that. It has left us a determined team. We're dedicated to getting back into the World Series."

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The Orioles, of course, entered the match against the Mets labeled as the best team in baseball. They had won the Eastern Division of the American League by 19 games.

They had routed the Twins, the Western titlists, in three consecutive games. They had it all and they would end the myth of the Mets.

It took only five games, but it was the myth that became a reality.

"Things will be different in the '70 World Series," said the manager.

And this is what people are thinking today as Earl Weaver again tries to win sports' greatest prize.

This time I believe the old bush league manager can pull it off.